

THE FOREST AND THE OATH

A strategy game from The Silmarillion

Design analysis and visual direction | 29 September 2026

Recommendation: a single-player, isometric narrative strategy game about sustaining a small homeland during the wars of Beleriand. Lead people, negotiate commitments, protect routes, and decide what can be preserved. Let tiny figures inhabit an immense, expressive, painted world.

Working title only; not an announced or licensed product.



Proposed Brethil crossing: small travellers and a modest camp inside a dominant landscape

This original concept plate studies composition and scale. It is an invented local scene, not a canonical map or a working game. Generated with the built-in image-generation tool; the prompt accompanies the image in `art/concept-prompt.txt`.

01 / The game I recommend

Play an original march-warden of Brethil, entrusted by Halmir with the safety of several woodland settlements and their crossings after the loss of Tol Sirion. You have limited people, food, time, and authority. Neighbours can help, but they have their own obligations. A successful campaign leaves a community capable of living without you.

This setting directly connects the desired visual scale to the player's role. You can care deeply about a tiny person crossing a huge river because you know what they carry, who is waiting for them, and what your last decision cost them.

Decision	Recommended starting point
Genre	Turn-based regional strategy with character-led councils and brief field visits
View	Fixed isometric composition; pan and zoom; landscape dominates
Player authority	Delegated local responsibility; Halmir remains the canonical lord
Main verbs	Observe, provision, negotiate, promise, assign, escort, conceal, defend, withdraw
Main campaign target	12 weekly turns over one invented local crisis; roughly 4-6 hours, to test
Combat	Small-company encounters resolved through plans, terrain, warning and morale
Emotional centre	The tension between keeping a promise and keeping people alive
Visual centre	Beautiful, vulnerable human activity within enormous woods, rivers and old places

Why Brethil: its people hold negotiated freedom with a duty to guard the Crossings of Teiglin; refugees actually arrive there; Halmir and Beleg actually cooperate effectively. There is room for local invention and meaningful success within the published history. [B: 182-183, 192-197]

The proposed player, office, weekly timetable, settlements, incidents and rules are additions. This report does not claim that the book describes this campaign.

First playable test: one crossing, two inhabited clearings, an alternative woodland route, six original speaking characters, three field parties and eight turns. Test whether a conversation changes the next map decision before expanding the geography.

02 / What the whole book contributes

The strongest adaptation principle is that **power changes relationships before it changes borders**. The major disasters repeatedly arise from possession, bad counsel, pride, damaged trust, and an inability to relinquish something beloved. Military force matters, but it rarely explains the whole outcome.

Creation and stewardship. The *Ainulindalë* makes the world an interdependent work whose makers understand only part of it. Aulë and Yavanna make the claims of craft and living things concrete. A strategy system can therefore ask what construction enables, whom it serves, and what it damages. This is an interpretation for design, not a canonical ecology ruleset. [B: 26-33, 56-59]

The First Age. The jewels are irreplaceable works, inherited claims, and concentrated memory. The oath converts desire into an obligation that outlives its originator. The realms are politically divided and geographically specific; apparent security can conceal strategic weakness. Heroes rescue and preserve as often as they conquer. [B: 89-114, 135-163, 201-325]

Númenor. Fear of death becomes a political vulnerability. Sauron loses the military confrontation yet gains access to the court and progressively captures its judgment. Material growth continues while the society becomes crueler and less secure. A game should distinguish prosperity, legitimacy, safety, and freedom: a rising production total cannot represent all four. [B: 327-349]

The Rings and the Third Age. The desire to preserve beauty makes dependency attractive. The Three remain bound to the One despite Sauron's never having touched them. Ending the enemy's power also ends a form of preservation. This gives the design a powerful late-game question: which protections must you relinquish for a future to exist? [B: 360-362, 370-378]

The later works inform the design's systems and possible future campaigns. Their characters, technologies and artifacts do not migrate into First Age Brethil. Gandalf, Númenórean fleets and Rings of Power have no place in this opening campaign.

Preserve genuine hope. Pity, friendship, skilled work, rescue, and voluntary sacrifice are effective forces in this book. Constant betrayal would be as reductive as constant military triumph.

03 / Turn the themes into decisions

Source pattern	Proposed playable system	What the player must weigh
Fëanor's oath expands the field of enemies; Finrod's promise instead becomes costly loyalty. [106, 209-217, 319-324]	A commitment ledger recording beneficiary, witnesses, terms, deadline and conflict	Whether to fulfil, renegotiate or break a particular obligation; no universal oath-corruption meter
Melkor's rumours pass through trusted people; captives can be coerced or unjustly suspected. [89-92, 195]	Reports with named sources, age, corroboration and uncertainty	Time spent checking an account versus time lost responding
Hidden cities survive through secrecy but become attached to their isolation. [158-160, 303-307]	Routes have both usefulness and exposure	Opening a road improves movement while revealing where people live
The Dragon-helm draws followers and reveals Túrin's identity. [260-261]	Public symbols change recruitment and enemy knowledge	Whether prestige is worth visibility
A bridge improves access to Nargothrond and later admits disaster. [268, 270-272]	Infrastructure changes the route network for both sides	Immediate capacity versus the cost of defending or dismantling it
Idril prepares an escape route despite complacency. [306-309]	Reserve plans, shelters and withdrawal orders	Investment in an option that may look wasteful until it saves lives
Isildur rescues a fruit of Nimloth before the tree is destroyed. [341]	Living heritage that can be carried and replanted	Preserving a future rather than keeping every present possession
The Rings preserve while binding their users to another power. [361, 370-378]	Support agreements with visible dependencies	Whether to retain a benefit that compromises future independence

All rules in this table are proposals. The examples are evidence for their dramatic value, not instructions to reproduce every event in one campaign.

Make consequences spatial. A broken promise closes a ford to your messengers. A negotiated welcome creates a new inhabited clearing. A damaged alliance removes a guide, making a route longer. A rescued craftsperson repairs a boat. Players should be able to see the political story in the map.

Keep consequences explainable. After resolution, show the observed cause, remaining uncertainty and new choices. Avoid a hidden morality score that declares the player's ending without revealing how it was earned.

04 / Where to set the game

These are design judgments, not audience research or commercial demand evidence.

Campaign	Strength	Principal difficulty	Verdict
Brethil after Tol Sirion's fall	Negotiated autonomy, refugees, forest geography, limited forces and successful cooperation	Much everyday life must be invented carefully	Best first campaign
Havens of Sirion late in the First Age	Displaced communities, shipbuilding, an intensely contested heirloom, approaching disaster	Major outcomes constrain the player; Elwing must retain agency	Strong later campaign about sanctuary and departure
Gondolin before its fall	Monumental architecture, secrecy, competing counsel, engineering and evacuation	A city-scale production burden; foreknowledge can trivialise decisions	Strong focused expansion once the core systems work
Númenor under mounting court influence	Political persuasion, prosperity, complicity, mortality and naval logistics	A different map, institutions, timescale and cast	Best alternative if court politics is the priority
All Beleriand across the First Age	Maximum historical scope and many factions	Generations, fixed biographies, huge writing/art load, competing game scales	Defer; too broad to validate this concept

Recommended temporal boundary: an invented twelve-week interval around Halmir's response to the fall of Tol Sirion, while Sauron still holds the island and before Lúthien liberates it. Do not compress all the remaining First Age disasters into those weeks. Halmir and Beleg's defense is the historical anchor; the player's local contribution is invented. Their victory begins years of relative security, so a faithful continuation cannot immediately reset Brethil to endless identical invasions. [B: 195-197, 217]

Recommended geographic boundary: a playable part of Brethil, with Teiglin on its western/southern side and Sirion on its eastern side. Brithiach and the Crossings of Teiglin are different places on different rivers. Tol Sirion lies upstream and remains an off-map source of danger. [B: 149-155, 394-395, 442-446]

A regional overview can show the surrounding powers and routes without pretending that a single walking map spans the continent. Local maps contain playable clearings, trails, slopes and fords; the overview contains travel commitments and reports.

The intended audience is a hypothesis: players who enjoy planning under pressure, strong writing and atmosphere, and who tolerate deliberation between actions. The first test must include both Tolkien readers and players unfamiliar with the names.

05 / The strategic loop

One turn is one week. Time advances only when the player commits orders. Looking around, reading and comparing plans are free; a field investigation uses a party's weekly assignment. An individual character cannot attend a distant council and lead an expedition in the same turn.

- 1. **Hear reports.** See the location, messenger, age and confidence of each claim. A route can be unexplored, recently observed or known to be threatened.
- 2. **Inspect or investigate.** Examine known ground now, or plan a scout assignment into unknown ground. Dispatched scouts report after the week's resolution, informing the next council; their future findings cannot improve this week's other orders retroactively.
- 3. **Convene a council.** Negotiate shelter, work, escorts and access. People may consent, refuse or offer alternatives.
- 4. **Issue orders.** Assign parties, provisions and materials. Choose routes, priorities, acceptable risk and fallback conditions.
- 5. **Commit the week.** Resolve movement, work, contact and encounters. Critical new situations can pause resolution for a bounded decision.
- 6. **Return to the consequences.** Changed places, injuries, arrivals, testimony and obligations become next week's situation.

State	Representation	Purpose
People and labour	Named officers plus household groups; each party gets one assignment per week	Every deployment has an opportunity cost
Provisions	Stocks at locations, transport capacity and consumption	Supply routes matter; no global warehouse
Materials	A small pool of practical work supplies	Repair, shelter and defense compete without a huge crafting tree
Readiness	Fatigue, wounds, cohesion and equipment by party	Repeated success cannot erase exhaustion
Relationships	Specific trust, grievances, access and promises	Cooperation has a history; trust is not a spendable coin
Exposure	What an adversary plausibly knows about routes and settlements	Secrecy emerges from actions and observation

Success: sustain a viable local community and a workable route network while meeting or honestly revising its commitments. Outcomes can include a defended homeland, a negotiated smaller refuge, or a successful local relocation. Their value depends on people, autonomy, remaining stores and relationships, not hectares controlled.

Failure: the community loses the capacity to sustain or relocate itself. Local losses should normally open difficult recovery choices. Do not force every viable campaign to end in annihilation because the wider legend contains tragedy.

06 / A worked turn: The Far Bank

This is a wholly invented scenario for testing the rules, not a scene or quotation from Tolkien. All quantities are provisional balance values.

Week 3. Six resident household groups consume six provision units per week. The accessible local store holds 22 units; ordinary household work brings four more, independently of your deployable parties. Three exhausted refugee groups reach the far bank. Feeding them requires three more units weekly. A previous patrol saw tracks on the northern approach but could not identify their age. A storeholder offers six additional units, outside the 22 and deliverable locally this week, if you promise to protect her outlying clearing next week.

You have three parties: a scout party, a work party, and a flexible escort party. Escorting the refugees and preparing humane temporary shelter take the work and escort assignments. Northern reconnaissance takes the scout assignment. Your routine western patrol will therefore be absent.

Plan	End-of-week provisions	Commitment and next problem
Admit and provision all three groups; investigate north	$22 + 4 - 9 = 17$	Saves the arrivals; leaves the western path unwatched
Same plan, accepting the storeholder's offer	$22 + 4 + 6 - 9 = 23$	Gains time, but reserves an escort commitment next week
Guide the arrivals to a consenting allied clearing	$22 + 4 - 6 - 3 \text{ travel rations} = 17$	Uses an escort and requires an actual prior agreement; capacity and welcome are checked
Refuse entry and assistance	$22 + 4 - 6 = 20$	Conserves supplies; people remain exposed and their future is tracked

The first plan leaves a weekly deficit of five at unchanged collection. Refugees become potential workers after rest; the player must still decide whether to improve provisioning, share burdens or arrange onward travel. This arithmetic makes compassion a planning challenge without defining it as failure.

Counsel scene, original writing:

The storeholder: "I will open the store. Tell me whose watch stands outside it when the next cart comes."

Memory: "She has asked you once before."

Mercy: "Those on the bank have not eaten today."

Craft: "The smaller carts can cross. The heavy one cannot."

The voices reveal competing considerations; none selects the answer. Interview evidence may change a route assessment or reveal a needed skill. It must not secretly guarantee that kindness triggers betrayal. The source explicitly includes innocent escapees harmed by suspicion. [B: 195]

07 / War, uncertainty and lasting choices

Combat should test the plan already made. A forest defense asks where to watch, how to delay an advance, when to conceal movement, and which route remains open for withdrawal. At this scale, supply and local knowledge matter as much as a weapon rating.

Use a small-company order model: **watch, escort, screen, ambush, hold, withdraw**. Display known terrain and readiness modifiers before commitment. Show confidence bands when the enemy's strength is uncertain. Do not reveal exact hidden unit counts behind a mysterious percentage.

A confrontation can resolve on the existing local map in several phases: contact, response, withdrawal or pursuit, then rescue and recovery. The player changes a limited number of orders when new evidence appears. Elaborate individual action-point combat would become a second full game; defer it until the strategic loop has proven insufficient.

Retreat must work. A rear guard, a prepared ford and an escort destination create a successful withdrawal. Injuries, abandoned materials and broken contact are meaningful costs. Slaughter should not be the only significant combat outcome.

No consequence-free delay. Repeated scouting improves knowledge while consuming time and readiness; food is still consumed, arrivals still need shelter, and observed enemies may move. Conversely, opening a menu or reading a conversation never advances time.

Separate uncertainty from arbitrariness. A report can be incomplete or wrong, but its source and age are visible. Outcomes follow the world's state and the issued orders. A fixed seed and event log support debugging and consistent reloads; difficulty changes information or resources, not secret punishments for particular moral choices.

The *Nirnaeth Arnoediad* supplies the clearest source lesson: a coalition can lose through withheld participation, delayed intelligence, provocation and betrayal. Individual acts of defense still matter, especially when they preserve a retreat. [B: 237-244]

Legendary enemies remain exceptional. A dragon is a landscape-changing emergency requiring evacuation, alliance or an extraordinary story, rather than a repeatable source of crafting materials. Ordinary campaign pressure comes from patrols, raids, exposure and the growing inability to cover every route.

08 / Characters worth looking after

Small figures require strong identity elsewhere: a distinctive silhouette, a useful skill, a place in the community, a contradiction, and a relationship the player can change. The following six roles are original proposals; their titles are temporary design labels, not invented Elvish names.

Character	Competence and desire	Complication	Map silhouette
The Warden, player	Organises routes and commitments; wants to justify entrusted authority	Can become controlling while believing every decision protects others	Weathered short mantle, walking staff, small pale shoulder patch
The Storekeeper	Knows supplies and households; wants fair contribution	Remembers emergencies in which her generosity was treated as an unlimited resource	Ochre wrap, keys and narrow tally board
The Scout	Reads weather, tracks and cover; wants the forest's independence	Shares crucial knowledge reluctantly when outsiders propose a road	Grey-green hood, low profile, long unstrung bow
The Boatwright	Repairs boats and crossings; wants good work to endure	A technically excellent crossing can also expose a refuge	Rolled sleeves, blue apron, carried tool roll
The Refugee Organiser	Keeps families together; wants a future beyond being a guest	Refuses to let gratitude become permanent political submission	Repaired russet cloak, bundles, decisive leading gesture
The Boundary Envoy	Connects local wardens to Doriath; wants reliable cooperation	Underestimates how costly delay feels to people with short lives	Slender silver-grey outline, restrained leaf-shaped fastening

Let them disagree about methods without assigning each one a single permanent ideology. Give them private generosity, practical irritation and humour. A polished portrait cannot compensate for dialogue that only repeats a resource tooltip.

Canonical presences: Halmir grants and judges the mandate; Beleg is an independent ally; Emeldir's evacuation informs testimony and the refugee community. Any direct meeting with her needs a deliberate placement in the chronology. Haleth is remembered through precedent and her mound, not alive in this period. [B: 182-183, 192-197]

Character art: angular, expressive painted portraits; material wear; unusual but coherent costume shapes; selective warm accents. Show age, attention and fatigue rather than giving every person royal armour. Faces receive detail in portraits and conversations; map bodies retain believable small proportions.

09 / Tiny people, enormous world

Make the environment large by composition, continuity and traversal choices. A zoomed-out scene containing an oversized hero beside an empty background will not deliver the intended feeling. Trees, river systems, slopes and paths must set the visual rhythm; human activity occupies small, intentional pockets.

Use a fixed orthographic camera. A starting angle is 45 degrees around the vertical axis and approximately 35 degrees down from horizontal. This is a compositional baseline to test, not a requirement to display a diamond grid. Fixed rotation lets artists control overlap, light and the path of the eye.

View at a 1920 × 1080 reference viewport	Starting scale target	Information shown
Regional overview	Parties aggregate to symbols when bodies become too small	Routes, delays, access and areas of uncertainty
Default playable view	Human figures about 18-28 px high, or 1.7-2.6% of viewport height	Distinct small groups, paths, camp activity, directional movement
Optional inspection zoom	Figures about 45-70 px high	Clothing shape, work gestures and local objects
Conversation / object inspection	Separate portrait or detail illustration	Face, emotional expression, craft and provenance

These are proposed targets requiring actual playtests. The concept image shows the intended relationship but does not verify exact runtime sizes.

Readability tools: readable silhouettes; two or three value groups per costume; a small accent that survives zooming; a discreet selected-ground marker; optional outlines and names; keyboard cycling and a location roster. Selection regions can exceed the visible artwork. Never require someone to click an eight-pixel hand.

Occlusion: fade intervening tree canopies locally, reveal a character's ground position, and keep critical paths distinguishable from decoration. Do not solve the problem by enlarging every person or removing the forest.

Keep roughly 85-90% of the default frame visually devoted to the world, with compact controls at its edges. Long conversations may temporarily use a larger side panel. Text size and interface scaling remain independent of map zoom.

The supplied illustrations already support this instinct: PDF 115 places a small procession within enormous ice; 147 and 194 subordinate inhabitants to terrain. Borrow that scale relationship while developing an original painterly language.

10 / Paint, places and objects

Art direction: dark but chromatically alive. Rain-blue stone, deep viridian woods, silver birch, old ochre cloth, amber shelter light and sparse vermilion. Use broad painted masses at distance and concentrated detail around decisions. Preserve visible brushwork and incomplete edges; avoid uniformly sharp texture, glossy surfaces and a constant brown wash.

Light has meaning. A camp's warm light can imply welcome and exposure at the same time. Moonlit paths reveal another route through a familiar place. The loss of light should be noticeable because the world has previously contained beauty. The opening cosmology and the Trees make light too important to reduce to a generic dark-fantasy filter. [B: 48-52, 96-102, 124-127]

Place	Visual identity	Strategic use
Teiglin crossing	Long dark water, exposed stones, tiny queues, low mist	Capacity, delays, escort and watched approaches
Inhabited forest clearing	Low roofs or shelters under high trees; work marks and stored bundles	Shelter, labour, local consent and provisions
Haleth's mound	Grass, a quiet rise and a clear margin in the trees	Memory, legitimacy and a council about inherited duties
Northern approach	Broken cover, ash carried by rain, tracks that cross older tracks	Report reliability, warning and defense in depth
Sirion boundary	Reeds, broad water and restricted passages	Diplomacy and access, distinct from the Teiglin crossing

Except for named geography and Haleth's mound, these local compositions are proposed art and level design.

Objects should have biographies. A repaired boat can belong to a household, transport food, and carry people away from a lost home. An inherited clasp may identify an obligation. A letter can be copied, delayed, entrusted or withheld. Inspecting an item should answer who made it, who needs it and what a decision about it changes.

The book's named examples reinforce this: the ring of Barahir authenticates a promise; Angrist enables a singular act and breaks under excess; the Nauglamír becomes a dispute over labour, possession and authority; Nimloth's fruit carries continuity through destruction. [B: 207-209, 228, 292-296, 341]

Keep unique legendary objects out of ordinary loot generation. Most usable props should be modest original things with specific local histories. Save detailed object paintings for objects that actually change a decision.

11 / What to take from Disco Elysium

The useful connection is expressive observation: the same person or place can invite competing interpretations, and those interpretations can change what the player attempts. The official Psyche descriptions explicitly give faculties biases and unreliable suggestions. The official Thought Cabinet description connects internalised ideas to dialogue, events and mechanical effects. [D1, D2]

For this game, propose five **inner perspectives**: Memory, Mercy, Craft, Vigilance and Pride. They belong to the original protagonist's psychology. They are not the Valar speaking and do not certify supernatural truth.

Perspective	What it notices	How it can mislead
Memory	Precedent, debts, altered testimony	Treats a present person as a repetition of an old betrayal
Mercy	Suffering and possibilities for repair	Underestimates the strain imposed on other vulnerable people
Craft	Materials, workmanship and practical alternatives	Assumes a social conflict can be repaired like a mechanism
Vigilance	Exposure, missing details and contingency	Confuses lack of certainty with evidence of danger
Pride	Dignity, manipulation and unacceptable terms	Makes retreat or apology feel like annihilation

These particular perspectives and effects are original design proposals. A strong perspective opens observations and arguments; it does not automatically make them right.

Beliefs become standing commitments. After repeated decisions, the player can adopt a policy such as keeping a refuge open or refusing unwitnessed bargains. Adoption changes default orders and expectations; revising it requires explanation and creates political consequences. This adapts the general idea of thoughts with mechanical force into governance. Do not reproduce Disco's named thoughts, portraits or interface.

Tone: intimate, perceptive and occasionally funny, with room for exhaustion and wounded dignity. Tolkien's world also needs sincerity, wonder and a credible good. Modern detective slang, borrowed political labels and reflexive cynicism would work against the material.

Keep most routine exchanges short. Reserve substantial conversations for disputed evidence, irreversible commitments and changed relationships. Essential facts must appear in the order preview and journal even if the player skips atmospheric text. No key strategic rule should be buried inside an ambiguous poetic aside.

12 / Agency within the legend

The recommended mode is **a local story consistent with the published history**. The player does not determine whether the Two Trees fall, whether Fëanor's oath exists, or whether Angband can be conquered by an ordinary local army. They determine who survives this crisis, which routes remain usable, what trust is repaired, and what form the community takes.

Use three evidence labels during development:

- **Source fact:** an event, identity or relationship established in the supplied volume, with a PDF page reference.
- **Interpretation:** a design reading of what makes that fact significant.
- **Invention:** an added character, conversation, settlement, mechanic or possible local outcome.

Do not make a legend-compatible campaign a disguised sequence of losses. Brethil has a source precedent for real local success. Preserve earned outcomes for the duration of the campaign. A later historical catastrophe need not retroactively invalidate the people or institutions sustained in this story. [B: 196-197]

Knowledge also has limits. The player may know the book, but their warden receives reports. Avoid fake mystery about famous events; build tension around costs, timing and the fate of original people instead. Hidden Gondolin is not an ordinary selectable shopping destination.

Authority has limits. Halmir, Beleg, households and allied powers can refuse. Refusal should be intelligible from promises, responsibilities and events. A recruit button should not turn every named hero into an obedient party member.

Keep the source's uncertainty. Its foreword acknowledges a composite text. Some lore is attributed belief; some outcomes are unknown. Amandil's ultimate fate, for example, is not established as a successful second Eärendil mission. The explanatory Waldman letter also reflects an earlier state of the mythology; its notes explicitly correct the old numbering of Númenor's kings. [B: 6-8, 344, 458]

If a later game offers alternate history, label the divergence and let major events truly change. Mixing fixed outcomes with promises of unrestricted freedom would be misleading. That larger mode requires additional writing and simulation and is outside the first prototype.

13 / How to build a convincing first slice

Validate three things in order: the decision, the visual scale, and their combination. Do not commission a continent before proving that a changed relationship produces an interesting route decision.

Gate	Deliverable	What would justify proceeding
1. Rules test	Paper or simple digital map; eight turns; three parties; food, routes and commitments	Players understand why they cannot do everything and try more than one viable plan
2. Visual test	One painted crossing, six silhouettes, a portrait pair, zoom/selection/occlusion	Small figures remain findable; participants describe the world as vast rather than empty
3. Connected slice	Councils, field investigation, orders, resolution, consequence scene, save/load	Dialogue changes a plan; the changed plan alters a place or relationship
4. Production decision	Observed writing/art throughput, performance measurements, revised scope	The team can estimate a full campaign from completed work rather than illustration counts

Slice budget: three connected local areas; six original speaking roles; three usable parties; three disputes sharing resources; one incursion with hold and withdrawal outcomes; one surviving-state epilogue. Use text and a small original soundscape first. Full voice acting, multiplayer, generational simulation, a full continent and a second tactical game are deferred.

Suggested technical path: for a desktop-first prototype, test Godot with a fixed orthographic Camera3D, simple terrain/occlusion geometry, painted surfaces and modest character models. The official camera supports orthographic projection; the quality of the painterly result still depends on art direction and rendering work. [G1]

If the first deliverable must run in a browser, a 2D Phaser scene with layered painted backgrounds and sprites is an alternative prototype path. [G2] No platform was specified, so browser deployment is not a requirement and no engine is finally selected here.

Keep the turn simulation independent of the renderer. Save parties, stocks, route state, commitments and the event log. Author dialogue against those shared variables. Chunk the map, limit active detail to visible areas, and measure zoomed-out performance; a single enormous texture is not a plan for a vast world.

No game has been implemented or playtested as part of this report. The included image is concept art only.

14 / What could make this fail

Risk	Early evidence	Response
The game is mostly conversation	Players cannot name a map decision changed by dialogue	Make each major conversation alter access, information, labour or a commitment
It becomes generic survival management	Players remember only food totals	Attach costs to named people, actual places and previous promises
Tiny figures become frustrating	Frequent missed selections or lost parties	Larger hit regions, roster selection, outlines, occlusion handling and optional zoom
Vastness becomes waiting	Players spend time crossing known empty ground	Dispatch through the route map; let field scenes begin at the meaningful location
Tragedy makes decisions feel pointless	Players assume everyone dies regardless	Demonstrate a lasting rescue and a lasting alliance in the first three turns
One cautious plan dominates	Every test group waits and scouts indefinitely	Give observation real time/labour costs and offer productive, evidence-based risks
Writing/art scope grows uncontrollably	New places require unrelated assets and branching stories	Revisit locations in changed states; build events from persistent shared systems

Proposed acceptance checks: in an initial six-person test, at least five participants can identify a party's next destination and select it without help; at least four can explain two consequences of a commitment; at least two viable plans emerge across repeated runs. These are iteration gates, not statistical proof of demand. Verify colour-independent route/status cues, scalable text and reduced-motion options.

For emotional validation, ask which person they worried about and why. For strategy validation, ask which order they changed after hearing new evidence. For visual validation, test a silent first impression before providing the intended art description.

Production dependency: a public direct adaptation needs its rights position resolved before a commercial plan is built around it. The Tolkien Estate's published FAQ restricts adaptation permissions; this report does not establish a licence or a clearance route. If rights are unavailable, preserve the general design principles in a substantially original world rather than merely renaming Tolkien's people and places. [R1]

Team size, platform, budget and production schedule are unknown. The prototype is the next basis for estimating cost. No revenue, demand or delivery-date claim is supported by this reading exercise.

15 / Reading scope and evidence

Source B: the supplied *silmarillion.pdf*, 461 PDF pages, titled *The Silmarillion Illustrated* in its metadata, by J. R. R. Tolkien, edited by Christopher Tolkien, with Ted Nasmith illustrations. References in this report use **1-based PDF page positions**, not printed folios. Chapter titles are the fallback locator across editions.

The full extracted text was read in four contiguous assignments: 1-115, 116-230, 231-337 and 338-461. This includes the front matter, Waldman letter, every narrative work, pronunciation note, complete index and name-elements appendix, publisher material, and relocated letter footnotes on 450-458. Image-based family tables and maps were inspected separately. Text extraction sometimes joins words; this is not a diplomatic transcription or a comparison of Tolkien's textual variants.

The report's coverage of the whole book informs a deliberately narrow first game. Coverage does not mean all source material should become playable content.

Material read	PDF pages	Contribution
Editorial foreword, preface and Waldman letter	6-24; notes 450-458	Composite text, art and possession, mortality, preservation, source qualifications
Ainulindalë	25-34	Interdependence, partial knowledge, making and discord
Valaquenta	35-42	Distinct forms of power, pity, craft and care
Quenta Silmarillion, chapters 1-9	43-115	Light, ecology, migration, kinship, rumor, oath and exile
Chapters 10-18	116-200	Institutions, geography, secrecy, human settlement and broken defenses
Chapters 19-24	201-325	Rescue, coalition, identity, attachment, succession, evacuation and relinquishment
Akallabêth	326-355	Mortality, political capture, false prosperity and refuge
Of the Rings of Power and the Third Age	356-378	Dependency, preservation, vigilance and the cost of ending an age
Genealogies and division of the Elves	379-383	Relationships and peoples; checked as images
Pronunciation, index, name elements	384-441	Identity, aliases, naming burden, geography and language
Maps	442-446	Separate river crossings and regional relationships; checked as images
Bibliography, publishing matter, notes and repeated contents	447-461	Edition context and displaced footnotes

16 / Chapter-to-design coverage

Each row records material read and its most useful design implication. The implications are recommendations, not rules stated in the book.

Quenta chapter	PDF pages	Adaptation finding
1. Of the Beginning of Days	44-54	Light, protection and destruction change the conditions of life
2. Of Aulë and Yavanna	55-60	Craft and living systems both make claims on the world
3. Of the Coming of the Elves and the Captivity of Melkor	61-70	Fear, invitations and geography divide migrations
4. Of Thingol and Melian	71-73	Private attachment can redirect public history
5. Of Eldamar and the Princes of the Eldalië	74-82	Separation, gifts and craft produce distinct communities
6. Of Fëanor and the Unchaining of Melkor	83-87	Grief, brilliance and political trust intersect
7. Of the Silmarils and the Unrest of the Noldor	88-94	Rumours and defensive preparations can reinforce one another
8. Of the Darkening of Valinor	95-99	Catastrophe destroys a shared resource and transforms the visual world
9. Of the Flight of the Noldor	100-115	Commitments, logistics and betrayal create lasting divisions
10. Of the Sindar	116-122	Trade and mutual craft coexist with unequal protection
11. Of the Sun and Moon and the Hiding of Valinor	123-129	Refuge and withdrawal alter the world's available routes
12. Of Men	130-133	Mortality creates different horizons of judgment
13. Of the Return of the Noldor	134-147	Rescue and renunciation can repair a coalition
14. Of Beleriand and Its Realms	148-156	Geography supplies the strategic rules
15. Of the Noldor in Beleriand	157-163	Security, concealed wrongdoing and cultural authority interact
16. Of Maeglin	164-175	Valuable skill does not guarantee loyalty; coercion damages trust
17. Of the Coming of Men into the West	176-186	Settlement, autonomy and reciprocal duties anchor the proposed game
18. Of the Ruin of Beleriand and the Fall of Fingolfin	187-200	Displacement and local cooperation follow strategic catastrophe

17 / Final chapters and reference sources

Quenta chapter	PDF pages	Adaptation finding
19. Of Beren and Lúthien	201-235	Rescue, craft, restraint and freely chosen sacrifice can achieve what armies cannot
20. Of the Fifth Battle: Nirnaeth Arnoediad	236-248	Alliance preparation, intelligence, provocation and retreat determine lives
21. Of Túrin Turambar	249-287	Identity, counsel, reputation and infrastructure can compound danger
22. Of the Ruin of Doriath	288-299	Rival claims to an object destroy institutions and transmit violence
23. Of Tuor and the Fall of Gondolin	300-313	Attachment to a place can defeat good counsel; escape planning matters
24. Of the Voyage of Eärendil and the War of Wrath	314-325	Refuge, intercession and survival matter beyond possession or battlefield success

D1 - Disco Elysium, “Meet the Skills: Psyche.” Official developer description of biased inner faculties and contrasting interpretations. Supports the general psychological design connection; the proposed warden perspectives are original.

<https://discoelysium.com/devblog/2018/03/13/meet-the-skills-psyche>

D2 - Disco Elysium, “Introducing The Thought Cabinet.” Official developer explanation of internalised thoughts connected to dialogue, events and gameplay effects. Supports the general influence, not a recommendation to reproduce specific content.

<https://discoelysium.com/devblog/2019/09/30/introducing-the-thought-cabinet>

G1 - Godot, Camera3D reference. Official documentation of orthographic camera projection. The proposed art pipeline is a design recommendation, not a claim of a ready-made painterly renderer.

https://docs.godotengine.org/en/stable/classes/class_camera3d.html

G2 - Phaser documentation. Official description of its 2D browser framework and rendering options; supports the alternative prototype path.

<https://docs.phaser.io/>

R1 - Tolkien Estate, Frequently Asked Questions and Links. Published permissions and adaptation policy; consulted only to identify a production dependency, not to determine this project's legal position.

<https://www.tolkienestate.com/frequently-asked-questions-and-links/>

External sources checked during preparation. No film, television adaptation, wiki, or game adaptation was used to silently supplement the supplied book's canon.

Proposed next decision: approve or revise the Brethil premise and visual scale, then test the eight-turn slice. Its central question is concrete: can a conversation make you change a route, and can that route make you care about the people travelling it?